Revision Date:
10/01/2025

Background:
WINS is a state funded food benefit for CalFresh households (HH) that meet Work Participation Rate (WPR) requirements. WINS supports working families and helps improve the state's WPR.

Purpose:
This section details WINS eligibility requirements for the WINS program. This section is being updated due to sunset review and includes clarification regarding the CalFresh Notice of Approval/Denial/Termination Work Incentive Nutritional Supplement (WINS) Benefit (WINS 1239) notice requirements. There are no changes to policy.

Policy:
WINS is a $10 monthly food benefit added to the Electronic Benefit Transfer (EBT) account for qualifying CalFresh HHs. WINS is evaluated at:

- Initial application.
- Semi-Annual Report (SAR 7).
- Recertification.
- When the HH reports a change.

When determined eligible, the WINS benefit is issued prospectively between the 20th and 24th of the month until a change is reported that results in WINS ineligibility. WINS is issued at the case level, and not per individual. If two or more families are aided under one CalFresh case and are eligible for WINS, only one $10 WINS benefit is issued for the case.

1. WINS Terminology

Refer to the table below for WINS-related terminology:

Term	Definition
Parent	A natural, adoptive, or stepparent acting on behalf of a child.
Caretaker Relative	A relative (up to the fifth degree of kinship) acting on the behalf of the parent of a child.
Work-Eligible Individual (WEI)	An adult (or minor child head-of-HH) living with a child unless the parent is: • A minor parent and not the head-of-HH. • Ineligible due to immigration status. • Caring for a disabled family member living in the home. • Receiving Social Security Administration (SSA) Disability benefits. • In a HH receiving Tribal Temporary Assistance for Needy Families (TANF).
Non-Two-Parent/Caretaker Relative	A single parent with a child age 6 or older or a two-parent/caretaker relative HH with one WEI.

Unsubsidized Employment	A job where the employer does not receive public funds to help pay wages.
Subsidized Employment	A job where the employer does get public funds, such as TANF, to help pay wages.
Core Work Activities	Any combination of cumulative hours from the following: • Subsidized employment. • Unsubsidized employment. • Work experience (WEX). • Job search and readiness. • Community service programs. • Mental health/substance abuse domestic violence services. • Vocational education training. • Job skills training (directly related to employment). • Education (directly related to employment). • Satisfactory school attendance. • Work activities other than those specified.

2. WINS Eligibility Requirements

To qualify for WINS, a CalFresh HH must not have gross income that exceeds 200% of the Federal Poverty Level (FPL) and meet the following criteria:

- Not receiving CalWORKs or Tribal TANF.
- Have a child in the home who is:
    - Under the age of 18; or
    - Under the age of 19 if the child is still in high school and will graduate before their 19th birthday.
- Have at least one parent/caretaker relative who:
    - Is receiving CalFresh.
    - Meets the WEI definition.
    - Meets the required number of hours of core work activity hours.
- Provide verification of hours work in subsidized or unsubsidized employment.

3. WINS Work Hour Requirements

To be eligible to WINS, the WEI(s) must meet the following in subsidized or unsubsidized employment based on their HH type:

Hours Required Per Week	WEI HH Type
20 hours per week	Single custodial parent/caretaker relative with a child under the age of 6 (one WEI).
30 hours per week	Non-two parent/caretaker relative or single custodial parent/caretaker relative with all children aged 6-18 (one WEI).
35 hours per week combined, with at least 30 core work activity hours completed by one parent (one WEI)	Two-parent/caretaker relative (both working) with all children under the age of 18 (two WEIs).

If the verification provided does not include the hours worked, estimated work hours may be calculated as follows:

- Divide gross wages by the state minimum wage plus $0.50.
- For self-employed individuals, divide net income (gross minus 40% or actual expenses) by the federal minimum wage.

4. WINS Aid Codes and HH Scenarios

For information on WINS aid codes and WINS HH scenarios, refer to the WINS Desk Aid.

5. Mid-Period Changes and WINS Discontinuance

If the HH reports a change mid-period report, determine if the reported change meets mandatory mid-period reporting requirements and take action accordingly. If the WEI's hours fall below the required threshold, discontinue WINS benefits and issue adequate notice. For additional information regarding mandatory mid-period reporting, refer to CalFresh Program Guide (CFPG) 63-283.

6. Notice Requirements

The WINS 1239 notice may be required depending on the WINS benefit status and specific case circumstances. The WINS 1239 approval and discontinuance notice will auto-generate in the automated system.

WINS Status	Notice Requirement
Approved	Issue the WINS 1239 approval notice.
Discontinued	Issue the WINS 1239 discontinuance notice in the month the ineligibility occurs (10-day timely notice is not required).
Denied	The WINS 1239 denial notice should never be issued when a HH fails to qualify for WINS during an initial evaluation. If a HH specifically requests to be evaluated for WINS (such as during a voluntary or mid-period report) but does not qualify for it, verbal notification is acceptable and must be documented in the case record. If contact is unsuccessful, issue the WINS 1239 denial notice.

7. Cases Approved for Transitional CalFresh (TCF)

HHs discontinued from CalWORKs are screened for WINS eligibility at the start of the TCF period. To be eligible for WINS during the TCF period, the HH's income must not exceed 200% of the FPL and must meet all other WINS eligibility criteria. If eligible, WINS benefits are issued for the entire TCF certification period.

During the TCF period, HHs are not required to report any changes, and no action should be taken if a voluntary change is reported. If a TCF HH reports a change or requests to be evaluated for WINS before the end of the TCF period, the HH should be informed of the option to wait until the TCF period ends and then recertify for CalFresh; or recertify CalFresh at the time of the request. For additional information on TCF, refer to CFPG 63-320.

8. Benefit Use

WINS can only be used to purchase food and cannot be applied toward repayment of CalFresh overissuance or CalWORKs overpayment claims.

WINS benefits will be expunged if there is no activity (purchases or withdrawals) on the EBT account for 274 days. Once expunged, WINS benefits cannot be restored, even if the HH remains eligible for CalFresh.

References:

All County Information Notice (ACIN) I-14-14, I-14-14E, I-27-15.
All County Letter (ACL) 13-71, 13-71E, 14-83, 22-62.
All County Welfare Directors Letter (ACWDL) December 5, 2014, February 2, 2015.
Manual of Policies and Procedures (MPP) 16-120, 42-716.

Sunset Date:

This policy will be reviewed for continuance on or by 09/30/2028.

Approval for Release:

10-1-25

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